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Title of the paper : Europe Beyond the Map: Borders as Power, Identity, and Negotiation — But Where Does It End?

Name of the author : Tristan Vezio

Name of the professor who will grade it : Mercè Kirchner Baliu

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Extension: **min. 2000 words - max. 2500 words (no footnotes or bibliography included).** In case you exceed this extension (or you don't reach the minimum) you will be penalized in the grading

Deadline: **Sunday February 15th before 2359h (through the task created at Scala).** LATE SUBMISSIONS WILL RECEIVE A PENALTY OF **1 POINT** OVER THE GRADE OF THE ESSAY **FOR EACH DAY (24 hours slot)** OF LATE SUBMISSION.

Can the borders of Europe be clearly drafted? Discuss the following quote: *"[t]he term 'European' has not been officially defined. It combines* ***geographical***, ***historical*** *and* ***cultural elements*** *which all contribute to the* ***European identity****. The shared experience of proximity,* ***ideas***, ***values*** *and* ***historical interaction*** *cannot be condensed into a simple formula and is subject to review by each succeeding generation. It is neither possible nor opportune to establish now the frontiers of the European Union, whose contours will be shaped over many years to come"* (European Commission (1992) 'Europe and the challenge of enlargement', Brussels, 24 June, in Kenealy 2022: 233).

"Borders are no longer merely the edges of territories; they are everywhere."
— Étienne Balibar, *We, the People of Europe?* (2004)

Where does 'Europe' begin, and where does it end? This geographical question proves to be much more complex, intertwining politics, geography, and social aspects. Unlike nation states, Europe as an entity has never been clearly defined and limited by fixed territorial borders. Borders have instead been shaped by historical factors, cultural exchanges, and political projections that cannot be defined solely by the geographical aspect. Étienne Balibar's assertion that borders permeate social and political life rather than merely marking territorial edges is particularly relevant to the European case, where borders function as dynamic processes rather than stable lines on a map. This spatial ambiguity is especially visible in the context of EU enlargement. Even after many years of integration, there remains no official definition of what it means to be "European." According to Anna Triandafyllidou and Ruby Gropas (2022), Europe is not an absolute entity but rather a contested notion whose significance develops through historical experiences, political discussions, and mechanisms of inclusion and exclusion. The lack of a definitive description is not coincidental but demonstrates the intricate character of Europe as a whole. The 1990s decade was a particular moment in this debate. In 1992, with the signing of the Maastricht Treaty, a new phase of political integration began, while simultaneously preparing for enlargement toward Central and Eastern Europe. It was in this context that the European Commission explicitly acknowledged the difficulty of defining Europe's borders. In *Europe and the Challenge of Enlargement*, the Commission argued that the term "European" combines geographical, historical, and cultural elements that cannot be condensed into a simple formula and concluded that it was "neither possible nor opportune" to establish the definitive frontiers of the European Union. This statement highlights our core theoretical problem : Europe is a complex entity that includes geographic areas, historical accounts, cultural associations, and political organizations. According to Gerard Delanty (2005), Europe is not found but created, constantly reinterpreted through differences and interactions. The difference between Europe as a region and Europeans as a political and cultural group thus continues to be uncertain. Building on the quote, the essay argues that, while the idea of `Europe´ can be approached through objective criteria, its borders cannot be clearly or definitively drafted; instead, they are continuously reshaped through political negotiation and historical change.

I. The apparent possibility of clearly defining Europe's borders

Geography is often presented as the most neutral and objective representation of realities for defining Europe. Historically, Europe has been viewed as a part of the Eurasian landmass, bordered by natural borders like the Atlantic Ocean, the Mediterranean Sea, and the Ural Mountains. This spatial comprehension seems to establish distinct and undisputed boundaries. As Dinan (2022), an Irish academic, at George Mason University, notes, initial accounts of European unity inadvertently depended on an unquestioned geographical understanding of Europe, regarding it as an inherently existing area instead of a politically formulated concept. Moreover, Norman Davies (1996) similarly shows how historical

accounts have repeatedly invoked geography to portray Europe as a coherent and bounded entity.

It would be delimited by physical spaces, such as seas or mountain, and this seems to be the first answer to our question : The Ural mountains and the Black Sea, in the Eastern part of the territory, the Arctic Ocean in the North, Atlantic Ocean in the West and the Mediterranean Sea are the physical delimitation of Europe. Yet defining Europe geographically does not resolve the deeper question of what constitutes “European” identity.

Beyond geography, Europe is frequently defined through reference to a shared historical and cultural heritage. Antiquity, Christianity, and the Enlightenment are commonly presented as the foundational pillars of European civilization. Anthony Pagden (2002) argues that Europe emerged as a civilisational idea rooted in Greco-Roman political thought, Christian moral traditions, and Enlightenment values such as reason, individual liberty, and universalism. This echoes the different `cultural' elements of the quote. Our past historical heritage, from Antiquity, to the Middle-Ages, towards the Modern Period would have shaped the vision that we have as “Europeans” going beyond the National sentiment of belonging. We can even go beyond this historical perspective, asking ourselves if Europe has not been socially and politically constructed and delimited, via, a cultural project, more than a politically or economically one. The cultural project would be to convey the core values, defended by the States, into their own borders and beyond, marking a clear differentiation between the inter-european space and the ´beyond´. Tzvetan Todorov and Nathan Bracher (2008) underline that democracy, human rights, and tolerance have become central to contemporary narratives of European identity. From this perspective, Europe could be defined as a coherent civilisational space unified by shared values and historical experiences, suggesting that its borders might be drawn on cultural rather than territorial grounds. In theory, the Copenhagen criteria, in 3 pillars, following the political, guaranteeing the rule of law, protection of minorities, and democracy, but also, economically, with the EU trade rules, and the capacity to transpose EU law, into domestic law, are mandatory criteria for accession. From this perspective, Europe could be defined as a coherent civilisational space unified by shared values and historical experiences, suggesting that its borders might be drawn on cultural rather than territorial grounds.

Last but not least, the European Union seems to offer us a clear definition of what Europe is at an institutional level. The European Union seems to provide a clear and structured definition of Europe. EU membership creates a distinct legal separation between insiders and outsiders via shared institutions, regulations, and policies. Andrew Moravcsik, in *The Choice for Europe* (1998) claims that European integration arises from rational decisions by states aiming for economic and political benefits, thus forming a limited political community. From this institutionalist viewpoint, well-defined boundaries are essential for political stability, governance, and democratic responsibility, establishing who is “in” or “out”. But if the system were Cartesian, and rational, how can we explain that a country that was in the European Union, and in Europe geographical space, such as the UK, went out ? How can we explain that within the ´European Identity´, and EU borders, countries such as Hungary, member of the European Union since 2004 contest the *Etat de droit*, or Slovakia,

openly criticising EU measures, on EU Law, freedom of speech, or the recent EU sanctions on Russia, following Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine.

II.The Limits of Fixity : A new Contested Political space.

As Jacques Delors once remarked, *"Europe is not just a map. Its borders are not only geographical but also historical, cultural, and political. Who can say where Europe begins and ends? Turkey, Russia, the Balkans… Each case challenges our ability to define who we are."* This statement encapsulates the core limitation of attempting to clearly define Europe's borders. The persistent ambiguity of borderline cases—whether geographical, cultural, or political—undermines any fixed definition of Europe. While shared values or historical perspectives may offer a starting point, as academic literature highlights (Neumann 1999; Rumelili 2004; Diez 2005), Europe's identity is constructed through differentiation and interaction, not through rigid boundaries. The Treaty on European Union (Article 49) further reflects this ambiguity by avoiding a final definition of Europe's borders, leaving enlargement as an open-ended process. Our core quote reveals that geography helps us define what is European identity. But what if it was the other way around ?

This is especially clear when looking at ongoing borderline situations like Turkey, Russia, and the Caucasus. These areas hold unclear positions that cannot be clarified solely by geography. Bahar Rumelili, turkish academic (2004) offers a nuanced analysis of Turkey as Europe's "internal other." Despite its geographic closeness, historical connections, and enduring ties to European institutions, such as the EU, Turkey has consistently been symbolically and politically barred from complete integration into Europe. Rumelili demonstrates that this exclusion relies not on objective geographical factors, but rather on identity-driven differentiation processes. The same applies, with the frontier towards the East. Russia has also been portrayed as part of Europe, and at the same time, differentiated from it, especially nowadays, regarding the geopolitical context in Ukraine or Caucasus. (Neumann 1999). These two examples echo, again the debate of European identity, in the definition of EU borders. Yes, the different axes of proximity, cited and explained in the quote, are important, but, "The East" in European formation, is special. Gerard Delanty (2018) argues that Europe should be conceived as a "heritage" shaped by encounters, conflicts, and exchanges, rather than as a homogeneous cultural unit grounded in immutable values. The "heritage" cited by Delanty, is not homogeneous, and is sometimes contested, in the rhetorical aspect, and, directly transposed to the question of frontiers. Political developments in countries such as Hungary or Slovakia illustrate that adherence to these values is neither automatic nor uncontested. Political developments in Hungary under Viktor Orbán and in Slovakia under Robert Fico illustrate internal contestation of EU norms. According to Thomas Diez (2005), the European Union identifies itself as a "normative power" by shaping its identity and that of others through the differentiation of norms. Nevertheless, this process unavoidably creates conflicts, as internal participants might challenge the norms that are intended to characterize Europe.

At the level of institutions, this political normative and at times uncertain, encapsulates the essence of the European Union. Article 49 of the Treaty on European Union and the Treaty on the functioning of the European Union (TFEU and TEU) indicates that "*any European State*" is eligible to seek membership, while intentionally omitting a precise definition of what constitutes "*European*. " This legal uncertainty turns the process of enlargement into a political endeavor that perpetually alters Europe's boundaries rather than establishing them definitively. Europe's borders are not drawn into straight and bold lines, but seen as a process of slow construction, and ultimately, a project of political diversification and enlargement in case by case. Scholars, like Bonomi and Mastrorocco (2015) turn the table, and show that the EU's reluctance to define its ultimate frontiers is not a weakness but a deliberate choice that preserves political flexibility and external leverage. The idea of *"dynamics",* and "*historical interaction"* in the quote is therefore crucial in our explanation.

III. Synthesis : Europe's Borders as Fluid, Dynamic and Negotiated

The European project, and particularly EU enlargement, should be understood as a continuous redefinition of what Europe is. The Europe of today is not that of the post-war period, nor that of the 1990s. Enlargement does not finalise Europe's contours; it constantly renegotiates them. As William Wallace (2002) argues in *Where Does Europe End?* Europe's boundaries are shaped less by geography than by political decisions and shared commitments. The 2004 enlargement illustrates this dynamic clearly. By integrating ten Central and Eastern European states, the EU did not simply extend its borders eastward; it redefined Europe by incorporating post-socialist societies and symbolically overcoming Cold War divisions. Europe's borders thus emerged from political choice and historical transformation rather than natural frontiers. Brexit provides an equally telling example. The United Kingdom, despite its deep geographical and historical ties to Europe, withdrew from the EU through a sovereign political decision. This demonstrates that European borders are not only expandable but reversible. Taken together, enlargement and withdrawal confirm that the European Union is not a fixed territorial entity but an evolving political project. The question of where Europe ends remains inherently open.

CONCLUSION :

To conclude, today's geopolitical context strongly echoes the insight expressed by the European Commission in 1992. Europe's borders are not lines waiting to be drawn, but political boundaries constantly produced through power, negotiation, and historical interaction. By affirming that the term "*European*" cannot be reduced to a simple geographical, historical, or cultural formula, and that it was "*neither possible nor opportune*" to establish the final frontiers of the European Union, the Commission anticipated the fundamentally open-ended nature of the European project. Rather than reflecting uncertainty, this absence of fixed borders was presented as a deliberate political choice, allowing Europe to adapt to future historical and geopolitical transformations but also to expand its model. Today's European debate on borders also conveys a key idea in critical geopolitics, which was famously expressed by Yves Lacoste, who stated that "geography is first and foremost used to make war." (1976). Borders are not neutral; rather, they are means of strategic

dominance, security, and power. Europe's geographical boundaries are inextricably linked to political battles for influence, identity, and sovereignty, as evidenced by the resurgence of territorial control as a key issue in the Ukrainian conflict. Therefore, the borders of Europe cannot be viewed as objective spatial facts but rather as sites of contestation shaped by geopolitical forces. In this sense, Europe is not a territory awaiting definitive borders, but an evolving political project whose limits remain open to reinterpretation.

This essay follows the Chicago Manual of Style, Author–Date referencing system.

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